Digital Mapping Tools for Australian History and Cultural Heritage

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The arrival of low-cost, high-affordance digital tools for online mapping brings both opportunities and challenges for historians in discovering and communicating the past to different audiences. This paper reports on the outcomes of experimental work by the team involved in Time Layered Cultural map (TLCMap) projects funded by two Australian Research Council Linkage Infrastructure, Equipment and Facilities (LIEF) grants. More generally, the presentation points to the exciting potential of the use of digital mapping tools in Australian historical and cultural heritage research.

A key tension in DH – in Australia as elsewhere – is the implicit impasse between space/labs/infrastructure, hardware/software platforms and provision, and the question of how scholars might work together in meaningfully interdisciplinary ways. TLCMap has made some creative interventions in this work. The contribution of TLCMap has been that it brings scholars and technicians together in an integrated and longitudinal way to investigate DH for historians and others. Plenty of issues remain for academics around the questions of DH outputs and quality measures, the future retention of datasets as well as digital products, among other aspects, but questions of data accessibility, digital responsibility, and the value of making data visible drive the significance of our work. TLCMap has put into practice what we have learned over the past two decades in DH and more widely, working within the limits of the technology but demonstrating and democratising the effort.

One of the factors driving the creation of the TLCMap platform and its capabilities was the production of the map titled Colonial Frontier Massacres in Australia, 1788-1930, led by Professor Lyndall Ryan of Newcastle University, and funded by an Australian Research Council Discovery Project grant. This map, first launched in 2017, records the massacre site locations, details of the individual massacres, and for the first time in the world, provides the sources and corroborating evidence for all recorded massacres across the whole of Australia. This online mapping tool was a significant step in the recognition of the duration and widespread nature of violence in Australia's history, and has received national and worldwide attention. It has become a highly valuable tool of social change and pedagogy for schools and researchers, including Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander researchers. Over the last six years Lyndall led subsequent years of development of the map to deepen and expand its reach with Bill Pascoe, Jennifer Debenham, Robyn Smith and Chris Owen. The project is publicly available at https://c21ch.newcastle.edu.au/colonialmassacres and as a layer on TLCMap. The success of this project demonstrated the usefulness of maps in interactive, engaging public scholarship, leading to the production of TLCMap, enabling humanities scholars to more easily create online maps supporting their research.

The innovation of the TLCMap platform is to adapt existing GIS technologies specifically for humanities and culture. It is a platform or infrastructure that links geo-spatial maps of Australian cultural and historical information, with additional features such as search, journeys, timelines, multilayers and analytics. The Gazetteer of Historical Australian Places (formerly 'Placenames') was the original centrepiece of TLCMap, for the first time providing a searchable combined Gazetteer of 'all' placenames in Australia. Since then a range of scholars involved with the various iterations of the TLC map team have tested and expanded its capability to include mobilities and flows, bounding boxes, and links to other forms of visual and textual data that can be interactively searched.

Creative data visualisation via online mapping is a powerful way to reveal historical patterns such as armed frontier conflicts, the journeys of mobile actors and flows of information in the past, legal prosecutions of mobile people, or the use of urban spaces. Online maps offer intuitive and visually accessible ways to present and promote findings. They allow users and audiences to interact with and explore a wide and deep set of linked information in ways not possible in print.

On the other hand, maps also present some challenges. Timeline maps, for instance, require precision about location and date, a precision which often conflicts with the complexity and uncertainty of historical materials. Questions of scale (generality versus particularity) and of the inevitable partiality of the data abound. Big data analysis can often complement but also test the precision of data and local and regional specificities of the archive. A latitude-longitude map is inherently structured by imperial spatial understandings and may be at odds with non-Western world views or the fluid, imaginative, ideologically-mediated lived experience of events.

This short paper showcases a range of approaches to these questions and issues identified by researchers involved with TLCMap and research involving cultural mapping and digital techniques. The iterations of the TLCMap team, led by Professor Hugh Craig of the University of Newcastle, has fostered a collaborative, creative and experimental environment to both build and share digital humanities and mapping skills and historical knowledge. This highlights the opportunities and challenges and the processes in the application of mapping to history projects. Overall, the paper highlights the value of digital mapping tools and projects in an era of open and available data sharing and research to ensure humanities research gains greater visibility to wider users, also demonstrating the value of investment in digital humanities project work.

See the TLCMap home page: https://tlcmap.org/

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